a. Liquid propellants

In liquid propellants, fuel and oxidiser are combined in a combustion chamber where they burn and come out from the base of the rocket with a great force. Liquid hydrogen, hydrazine and ethyl alcohol are the liquid fuels. Some of the oxidizers are oxygen, ozone, hydrogen peroxide and fuming nitric acid.

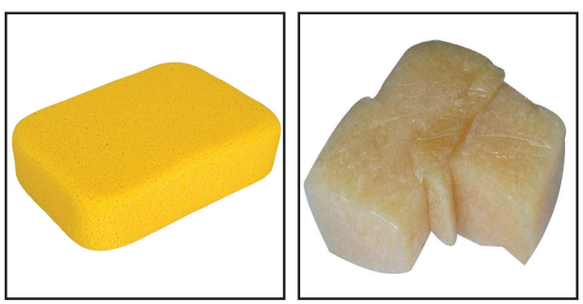


Liquid Hydrogen Fuming Nitric Acid

Figure 8.2 Liquid propellants

b. Solid propellants

In solid rocket propellants, fuel and oxidiser compounds are already combined. When they are ignited they burn and produce heat energy. Combustion of solid propellants cannot be stopped once it is ignited. Solid fuels used in rockets are polyurethanes and poly butadienes. Nitrate and chlorate salts are used as oxidizers.



Polyurethanes Poly butadienes

Figure 8.3 Solid propellants

c. Cryogenic propellants

In this type of fuel, the fuel or oxidizer or both are liquefied gases and they are stored at a very low temperature. These fuels do not need any ignition system. They react on mixing and start their own flame.

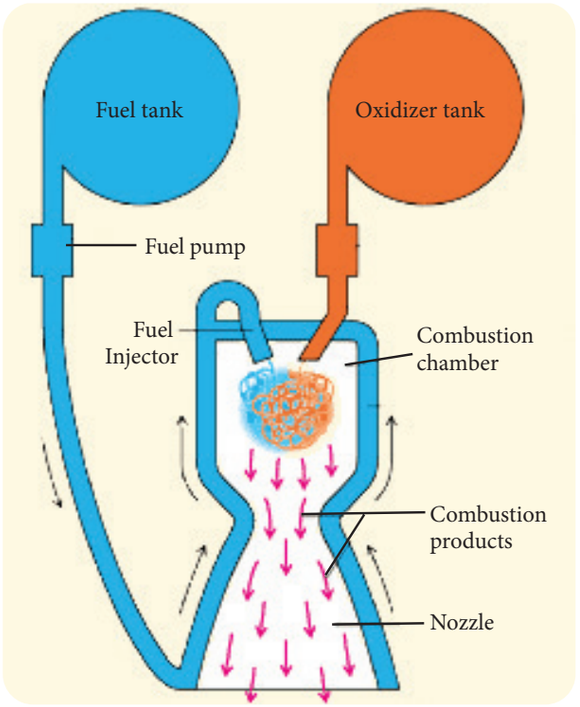


Figure 8.4 Cryogenic Fuels

8.1.3 Launching of Satellite

Activity 2

Take a balloon and blow air into it. Now let the air inside the balloon to come out. What do you observe? You can see the balloon moving in a direction opposite to the direction of the air. Rocket also moves almost similar to this.

Before being launched into the space, rockets will be held down by the clamps on the launching pad. Manned or unmanned satellites will be placed at the top of the rocket. When the fuel in the rocket is burnt, it will produce an upward thrust. There will be a point at which the upward thrust will be greater than the weight of the satellite. At that point the clamp will be removed by remote control and the rocket will move upwards. According to Newton's third law, for every action there is an equal and opposite reaction. As the gas is released downward, the rocket will move upward.

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